

Families of the Animals

As Noah and his family get off the ark, they exit parallel to all the animals “by their families” (Heb. *mishpakhah* / משפחה). This word appears 303 times in the Hebrew Bible, and this first appearance of the term is also the only time it is used of non-humans. In the parallel panel of 7:13-16, the animals are grouped together by species using the word “kind” (מין), a word used in Genesis 1:21, 24-25.

In deliberate contrast to “kind,” the narrator in Genesis 8:18-29 calls the animal species “families” as they exit along with Noah and his sons, who will become the three main families of the biblical world in Genesis 10. In fact, the word family will be used next of just these three sons (Gen. 10:5, 20, 31).

This creates an “animal families / human families” parallel, which is drawn upon in the prophets in a big way, like in the two framing visions of Isaiah 2 and 11.

Reflection Question

If the arrival of the flood was a cosmic collapse, then God’s salvation of humanity, the animals, and the land through the waters is an act of new creation. How do the biblical authors connect the post-flood restoration to creation?

Session 18: Noah's Sacrifice and God's Blessing

Key Takeaways

- The reason for the flood—the condition of the human heart—becomes God's reason to never again flood the Earth.
- Even though the land is cursed, God chooses to never again treat the land as though it is cursed.
- Noah is one example in the larger pattern that leads to the ultimate anointed one who will suffer on behalf of the wicked—a righteous one who will die for the wicked—and make atonement to open the way back to Eden.

Noah's Sacrifice and God's Response: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 8:20-22

- a 20 And Noah built **an altar** to Yahweh,
b **and he took from every pure animal**
b' **and from every pure bird**
a' and he caused to go up a going-up offering on **the altar**.

21 And Yahweh smelled the soothing smell;

The Curse Is Rescinded and No Death

- a and Yahweh said to **his heart**,
b "**I will never again curse the ground** on account of humanity,
a because the purpose of the **heart of humanity** is bad from his youth;
b' **and I will never again strike all life**, as I just did.

Cosmic Order Is Restored

22 For all the days of the land,
seedtime and harvest,
and cold and heat,
and summer and winter,
and day and night
will not stop."

The Blessing Is Released and Life Is to Bear Fruit and Multiply

And Elohim **blessed** Noah and his sons
and he said to them,

"Be fruitful and multiply and fill the land."

Genesis 8:20-22. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Adam to Noah (2020).

The Hero's Sacrifice in Mesopotamian Flood Accounts

The sacrifice of the flood hero motif is preserved in all of the existing Mesopotamian flood narratives.

I set up an offering stand on the top of the mountain.
Seven and seven cult vessels I set out,
I heaped reeds, cedar, and myrtle in their bowls.
The gods smelled the savor,
The gods smelled the sweet savor,
The gods crowded around the sacrificer like flies.

Gilgamesh Epic, Tablet 11

He put down [...],
Provided food [...]
[...]
The gods smelt the fragrance,
Gathered like flies over the offering.

Atrahasis Epic, Tablet 3

(140') Ziusudra, being the king,
stepped up before Utu kissing the ground (before him).
The king was butchering oxen, was being lavish with the sheep [barley cak]es, crescents together with [...]
[...] he was crumbling for him
[...]
[juniper, the pure plant of the
mountains] he filled [on the fire]

Eridu Genesis

He disembarked, accompanied by his wife and his daughter together with the steersman. He prostrated himself in worship to the earth and set up an altar and sacrificed to the gods.

Berosus' Babyloniaca

However, the function and result of the offering in the Mesopotamian accounts is different. This theme receives the most treatment in the Gilgamesh Epic.

The gods crowded around the sacrificer like flies.
As soon as Belet-ili arrived,
She held up the great fly-ornaments that Anu had made her in his infatuation, "O these gods here, as surely

as I shall not forget this lapis on my neck,
 I shall be mindful of these days, and not forget, forever!
 Let the gods come to the offering,
 But Enlil must not come to the offering,
 For he, unreasoning, brought on the deluge,
 And reckoned my people for destruction!"
 Suddenly, as Enlil arrived,
 He saw the boat, Enlil became angry,
 He was filled with fury at the gods.
 "Who came out alive? No man was to survive destruction!"
 Ninurta made ready to speak, and said to the warrior Enlil,
 "Who but Ea could devise such a thing?
 For Ea alone knows every craft."
 Ea made ready to speak, and said to the warrior Enlil,
 "You, O warrior, are the sage of the gods,
 How could you, unreasoning, have brought on the deluge?
 Impose punishment on the sinner for his sin,
 On the transgressor for his transgression ..."
 Gilgamesh Epic, Tablet 11

- The goddess Belet-ili holds up her fancy fly jewel necklace as a reminder to the gods that the flood should never happen again. In her speech, she wants the gods to learn a lesson from the flood. The indiscriminate slaughter of humanity is not in their own best interests because they almost starved without sacrifices.
- The final line shows the gods' new policy: Each sinner will face the consequences of their own actions.
- How different from the theology of the flood story.

Noah's Sacrifice and the Theology of the Flood Narrative

Like Abel, who was the first human to offer animal sacrifices at the door of Eden (see [Gen. 4:7](#)), Noah offers animal sacrifices at the door of the ark, which was a floating micro-Eden.

Noah's sacrifice does not placate a volatile and angry deity. Rather, his obedience and faithfulness to God's instructions qualify him to be a new *'adam*, a royal priest who offers up a valuable sacrifice on behalf of the new humanity.

Noah's priestly role was hinted at in Genesis 7:1-3 when he was directed by God to select ritually pure and impure animals to take onto the ark. Their purpose was not made clear, but now we find that these pure animals were qualified for a sacrifice of thanks.

Noah's sacrifice is a "going-up offering" (*'olah* / עֹלָה), which is traditionally translated as a "whole burnt offering" (see the description in [Lev. 1](#)). It was the most costly offering because the worshiper did not receive back any parts of the animal for a feast.

The going-up offering is the total surrender of a precious substitute who ascends before God's heavenly temple as a righteous and blameless representative to appeal to God on behalf of the offerer. In Noah's case,

he is already a righteous and blameless person, but his offering is not just for him but for all creation and all humanity yet to be born.

The result of Noah's sacrifice is made more clear by recognizing the hyperlinks back to the opening of the flood story. In Genesis 6:5-6, God states his reasons for bringing the flood.

Bookends of the Flood Narrative

Genesis 6:5-6 Instructor's Translation

⁵ **And Yahweh saw** (וריא יהוה) that great was the evil of the human in the land and **all the purpose of the plans in his heart was only evil all the day** (כל יצר מחשבות לבו רק רע). ⁶ And Yahweh regretted (נחם) that he made the human in the land, and he was grieved in **his heart** (אל לבו).

Genesis 8:21 Instructor's Translation

And Yahweh smelled (וירח יהוה) the pleasing smell, and Yahweh said to **his heart** (אל לבו), "I will not continue to treat as cursed any more the land (האדמה), on account of the human (האדם), **for the purpose of the heart of the human is evil from his youth** (יצר לב נאדם רע מנעריו) and I will not continue any more/again to strike all life as I have done."

Genesis 8:21 is a hinge-hyperlink text that is reaching back to strategic points in Genesis 1-8 and drawing the themes together into a coherent whole. Because of Noah's obedience and atoning sacrifice, God is no longer going to treat the land as cursed because of humanity's rebellious evil; rather, he is going to treat it as blessed despite the grim reality of human evil.

Genesis 8:21 Instructor's Translation

and Yahweh said to **his heart** (אל לבו), "I will **not continue to treat as cursed** (לקלל) **the land, on account of** (בעבור) **of the human**, for the purpose of the heart of the human is bad from his youth and I will **not again strike all life as I have done** .

Genesis 3:17 Instructor's Translation

Cursed (ארורה) **is the ground on account of you** (בעבורך), **in grief** (בעצבון) you will eat from it all the days of your life.

Genesis 5:29 Instructor's Translation

And he called his name Noah (נוח), saying "This one will give us comfort (נחם) from our work and from **the grief** (עצבון) of our hands from **the land which Yahweh has cursed**" (אררה)

Genesis 6:5-7a Instructor's Translation

⁵ And Yahweh saw ... that all the purpose of humanity's heart (לבו) was only evil all the day ... ⁶ And Yahweh **was grieved** (ויתעצב) **in his heart** (אל לבו) ... ⁷ and said **"I will wipe** (מחה) **away humanity ... for I regret** (נחם) **that I have made them ... for the land was filled with violence** (חמס). "

Is There No More Curse on the Ground?